

FUNDAMENTAL GUILT FOR NOT LOVING; OBLIGATIONS

Greetings, my dearest friends. God bless every one of you. Blessed is this hour. I welcome all of you, my old and my new friends alike. May this evening again give you renewed strength, renewed insight into your lives, your problems, and show you the road. May it give you a glimmer of light if you are hopeless and a new influx of strength if you feel weak.

The universe is forever expanding. All the cosmic forces -- the life force -- strain towards expansion, growth, union, and integration. Each individual entity, being a universe unto itself, follows this law towards growth and outgoingness. If these forces are disturbed, thrown out of their natural channels, love cannot prevail. All religions have always taught this, that love is the key to life. Without love, nothing counts.

On our path together so far, we have done more than merely taught this truth. We have together tried to understand what misconceptions and deviations prevent you from being in harmony with the universal forces so as also to move in the direction towards expansion and outgoingness and union. Your world on earth is indeed a troubled one. Life is difficult not only due to the struggle for physical survival, but in these times greater even is the struggle for the survival of the soul. This world is full of human beings whose soul forces are more or less disturbed. If the degree of disturbances is great, one refers to these people as mentally ill. If the degree is a lesser one, one calls them neurotic. The words do not matter, the terminologies change with the times. But the underlying cause is always the same -- the cosmic inner forces cannot flow organically because man does not dare to love, to let these forces free and grow in their natural, organic way.

For mankind as a whole, the result is strife, uncertainty, unrest, no peace. For the individual, the same holds true. Often he even becomes physically ill. He has trouble in his relationships, in his work. He cannot cope with life. He seeks all sorts of solutions but rarely discovers the real reason and therefore the real cure. A deep permeating guilt gnaws at his soul. This is a different kind of guilt than the more specific, often unjustified, guilts that smolder more on the surface of the psyche.

Some time ago, I went into detail on this subject. You may recall that I said that these little and unjustified guilts are a substitute for the real guilt of withdrawal, nonloving, isolation -- in other words for violating the great cosmic inner forces, of breaking the flow, as it were. This is a very deep-rooted guilt that prevents you from freedom and self-assertion, from the feeling that you deserve to be happy. Whenever the feeling of not deserving to be happy exists, it is necessary, my friends, to discover particularly, as it applies to each one of you, where and how you do not love, where pride, self-will, and fear, separateness, petty self-pampering, cowardice enclose you into a wall of isolation instead of you freely flowing and floating with the universal love current. The ensuing misery is due not only to the outer emptiness of your life (in the particular respects where no loving prevails), but even more so due to the deep and hidden guilt about it. It is not easy to unearth this

particular guilt, but if you truly want to find it, you will. As long as this is not found, verified, acknowledged, experienced to be so, all the other findings of images, misconceptions will not really help you.

We have often talked about the harm of the defense, the harm of a self-righteous or moralizing attitude (with yourself and with others), the harm of perfectionism -- the rigid standards that man complies with, often to the letter but seldom in the spirit, often so unnecessarily harsh, ascetic, life- and joy-negating. Why do you believe that all this exists? It is one of the solutions the psyche seeks, but the message is misunderstood by the conscious mind. The psyche says, "Give up your defenses against loving. Do not hold yourself apart! Do not be miserly with your feeling! You are wrong, you sin against the vital law of life. Make up for it, change, become a loving person." The conscious mind does not translate this message properly and therefore struggles to be "correct," "good," "right." But what is all that without love? Nothing. The substitute and atonement of perfectionism has indeed quite the opposite effect because it is even more unloving and more isolated. Its emphasis is on the self and how it appears in the eyes of others rather than on the other person. Therefore the soul gets more deeply involved in confusion and unrest, anxiety and guilt. Its messages become harder to decipher because self-alienation has progressed to a greater degree through these pseudosolutions.

We have gone into detail about all these aspects, but it now becomes necessary that you see with a better overall view the connection of these aspects with your deep-rooted guilt for nonloving, for disturbing the cosmic flow of outgoingness. The work we are doing together must finally and in the last analysis lead you to this area. For, then the road or curve upwards can begin. Until the finding of this area, this particular prohibition toward loving as it exists specifically within yourself, your seeking and finding within your soul, will often appear to be a downward curve. The road will often, in spite of occasional victories, seem hopeless. You will ask yourself, "Where does all this lead me? What is the good of it? How can I change?" But when you finally arrive at this point, not theoretically and intellectually, but when factually you see your selfish withdrawal from loving, regardless of how well you keep it concealed -- often by superperfectionism and right actions -- when this occurs, then and only then can you come to terms with yourself. Then you can make restitution. Then you can atone in a truthful and constructive way. You will begin to change in this respect. How? You will know if you truly want to. The expiation of this inner guilt, this guilt much deeper than all the little ones (often so unjustified and only using the unjustified ones so as to conceal the real ones), has to happen in order to make your soul healthy and peaceful; in order to like and to respect yourself; in order to be comfortable with yourself. The theoretical knowledge will not help. It will only help inasmuch as it might inspire you to set out to uncover this hidden area of your guilt for nonloving.

I might repeat once again -- because it is constantly being forgotten by my friends -- an action, a thought, an attitude is seldom in itself good or bad, right or wrong. Only of the most extreme sort of actions can this be said, and even then it is often misleading. But the value of an action, thought, or attitude can only be determined by whether or not it is motivated by love or by separateness, selfishness, fear, pride, etc. You still evaluate yourself and others by an act or an action, a deed -- in other words, by the outer manifestation -- and you disregard that which is behind it.

The same deed or attitude set forth by two different people, or perhaps even by one and the same person at different times, can in one instance be a loving act and can therefore be a liberating

experience for all concerned. Such a deed comes out of true concern for another, or from an issue that is at stake. The self here is not of primary importance. In another instance, the identical action can be a petty and degrading one. It might even be that the action outwardly appearing as the more noble is inwardly less so than another with the contrary appearance. This is very confusing for man. In order to evaluate an action of others, it calls for intuitive faculties. And these in turn can be sufficiently developed only if you learn to be truthful with yourself in this regard, if you can admit that often your very proper and correct behavior is not dictated by love at all.

From this, let us now consider another aspect in this respect. Very often you are convinced that your actions are in accordance with the standards of ethics and morals even though you may already have discovered that the motives are selfish and not loving. The motives may be those of compliance for the sake of approval and admiration, or for the sake of being loved, and not for loving. All these, of course, are selfish motives. While you may admit to these motives, you are convinced that your behavior leaves nothing to be desired. And yet, so often, even this is not true. That is, at times it is true; but the many times when the selfish motives also induce you to act selfishly, you do not see it at all. Your awareness is geared to the right actions, but not to the selfish ones. You still ignore the latter just as you ignored the selfish motives behind the former unselfish act. There is not the possibility but that selfish hidden motives induce you to live them out in actuality, and thus affect your surroundings. The guilt on account of this may then make you oversubmissive and give in when unjustified demands of others simply strengthens their own selfishness. You become confused and do not know when to assert yourself against unjustified demands and when truly to commit a giving unselfish act.

All this truthfulness with yourself finally serves the purpose of seeing that part of yourself in which you disturb the universal forces by prohibiting your feelings from loving. As you recognize this, you can cultivate the deep desire to change. You will find ways and means, inwardly and outwardly, to do so. You will let go of the prohibition for the sake of love. You will give up your little fears and misgivings, your imagined shames and vulnerabilities, for the sake of loving; for the sake of concern for others; for the sake of that which is good and constructive in itself. That will make you free. That will make you flowing and secure.

This, my friends, is not a sermon. These words, once again, are directed towards a deeply hidden layer or core of your being. No matter how well you rehearse and know the words, there is not a single human being in whom an inner part does not go along with this knowledge. Often, the stronger the knowledge in your brain, the more ignorant of it you are in a part of your being. Think well of all this. Try to apply it in your meditations and your work of a self-search, and find where and how this holds true for you. Do not apply it to others whom you may be resentful of -- the temptation is always great -- but see it in yourself. When you build up your perfectionism, your little guilts, try to find that behind all this is another kind of guilt. Perhaps if you reread this particular lecture of a few years ago, it will make more sense now after so much successful exploration.

At this point, I would like to express my happiness over the progress of quite a few of my friends. Their steady growth is a joy. And to those who feel stagnated, I say, do not give up. Do not give in. Surge on, and you too will soon feel yourself in the growing process of hopefulness and meaningfulness.

And now I would like to cover another topic: obligations. Many of you, in your self-search, have found a rebellion against living. This rebellion may take on various forms. It may be a manifest rebellion, or it may appear as sloth, apathy, stagnation, or as an utter sense of drabness. Everything becomes an effort, and you would rather do nothing at all. This, too, is rebellion. Now why does man rebel against life? It is not only the unhappiness or the pain he fears and rebels against. That, too, of course, is a reason. We know that and have discussed it. But there is also another reason.

Man resents the obligations, responsibilities, and duties that life imposes upon him. His fight for physical and psychological survival necessitates alertness, his power to make decisions, his willingness to make mistakes and learn from them, his willingness to expose himself, to do and act in the face of all attendant risks. When he does not say yes to life with regard to loving and relating, as well as to this aspect of it, he is pushed and dragged through it against his will. To quite some degree, if he wants to remain sane, he has to go through this active part of living, but he does so against the stream, as it were. He submits to it because he has to and not because he has said yes to it. If you do not willingly say yes to life in all its aspects, but allow yourself to be pushed by it, you cannot experience the dignity, the grandeur, the beauty of it.

This often goes to the extreme of your being unwilling to shoulder the responsibility of the moral obligations towards yourself. The accountability for your own misery is often mere words you know in theory, but when it comes to practical living, you wish to absolve yourself from this accountability. Subsequently, everything becomes a tedious task. In an advanced stage, this may even apply to the daily routines of living: eating, getting up, cleansing yourself, doing little chores. Even that becomes too much. Everything is an ordeal, and something rebels. If fundamentally you absolve yourself from accountability for your personal unfulfillment and trouble -- perhaps by not trying to find the inner connection -- then the final outcome is such a weariness that you no longer want to act. You want things done for you. You do not want to cope with decisions, with the strain of living; or, more accurately, what would be an exhilarating challenge becomes a strain. In this attitude of going along being forced by life because there is no other choice, life really does become an ordeal. There is no dignity and freedom in everyday chores of living -- the big as well as the little chores. How can you resolve that, my friends?

I would like to point out, again, that deep within there is something that has not said yes to the fight, to the challenge, that life puts to you also in a good sense, not in a hostile one. Find this little voice, bring it out into the open, and then see its meaning and significance. You will find that this voice belongs to a greedy child that wants everything and wants to give nothing. Ascertain the selfishness and laziness in this voice after it is taken out of hiding. Once you understand its nature, see it without false moralizing and justifications, you will desire to change. In mature responsibility is also love and unselfishness. Find where, why, how, and in what respect these are lacking in your lazy resistance against the assuming of responsibility in your life (or only doing so because you have to), and then you will eventually change your inner attitude and thus be with life rather than against it. When you are constantly tired and apathetic or when you constantly find yourself in the throes of depression and rebellion, investigate, my dearest friends, whether this very basic rejection of life does not hold true. When you discover it, allow it to come out just as irrationally and unreasonably as it exists. Do not be ashamed of it. Pronounce it to yourself, write it down, open up to the person you work with unrestrainedly with all the "comfortable" illusory ideals that you harbor. Maybe this voice will state that it just likes to vegetate and do nothing; that it does not wish to overcome, to

make efforts, to cope with people and their demands; to decide whether or not these demands are justified or not. It does not want to deal with obstructions, frustrations, criticism. It will tell you that you wish to just float.

You see, as in everything else, there is a healthy and also a destructive version of every aspect. So it is with the floating. There is the healthy floating of the state of being that comes from following the universal powers of love, from being active in life, saying yes to it. And there is the unhealthy version, the distortion in which one wishes to merely vegetate and not shoulder life at all. Only when you determine this unhealthy desire, concisely acknowledge it without self-deception, only then can you begin to find out why this seems so tempting. I venture to say there are many reasons with different individuals. But there are always certain common denominators which are fear of exposure to failure and inadequacy. This is pride. The desire for greater perfection than you have. This is a substitute for the love you don't allow yourself to feel. There is the link. You need not be so perfect if you love, and therefore you need not fear failure. If you do not fear failure so much, life would not become so difficult. It is often the inherent, often unconscious, terror of failure that makes life so arduous. So here we have the pride and the fear. Or you may say no to life because you cannot stand anything going against your will. You fear frustration, and therefore you do not willingly go along with life. There we are right back almost where we started from: pride, self-will and fear. As I said, they are the fundamental aspects that prohibit love and thus make the soul disturbed.

In each individual case, you will have to start from wherever you are conscious of feelings and reactions that indicate this condition. You may first find these aspects in your own terminology. They may at first appear to have no similarity with either pride, self-will, or fear. Yet, when you look at it closely and analyze the significance of these findings, you will always come back to this triad. And when you go even a step further, you will see that these three attitudes directly prohibit love and are the contrary of it. Because of it, you harbor this deep-seated guilt somewhere, whether or not you are now aware of it. Hence you take burdens of attitude and behavior upon yourself that are infinitely more difficult than the original state of love your soul wishes to grow into.

So, my dearest friends, my recommendation is that you set out to find the degree to which you have this rebellion against life, and in what particular way it exists in you. Find where, deep inside of you, you believe that no obligations means freedom. Then seek further to understand that this is wrong. At a later period, we will go into this topic more extensively. But for the moment, ponder over this lecture, both parts of it, and see the common denominator of these two parts!

And now, to your questions.

QUESTION: You mean to say then when a person's attitude toward life is correct, positive, then his feelings will be right also, and consequently his actions will be beneficial to himself and towards others? It all depends on this fundamental attitude, is that it?

ANSWER: Yes, that is so, that is what I am saying. This may sound very simple, but as you all know, it means a laborious path until one can bring this fundamental attitude in accordance with the universal forces.

QUESTION: We are planning to make some changes and improvements in the discussion sessions. Would you have any suggestions?

ANSWER: Yes. As far as technical details and handling are concerned, I will not go into that. This is something my friends can work out among themselves. The laborious road of trial and error holds a great benefit. It is a test for all concerned. Much can be learned from this by each individual. When you build up something in this way, you will gain a sense of accomplishment that has much more value than simply following advice and suggestions. Then your spirit will be in it -- and this, after all, is the only important thing that matters. Therefore the question is really how to go about it so that your spirit is in it -- with as many participants as possible.

In order to help in that direction, I will give a little reminder as to the purpose of it. The idea of these discussion groups is to help you put into practice, into practical assimilation, a theoretical knowledge, to apply it to your private lives. If the discussion, or the study group, as you may also call it, is approached with this outlook, and you remind each other constantly of that, this will keep you from theorizing. For the latter, you would not really need to meet. This comes so easy anyway for most of you. Let your aim be that you voice where one or the other does not emotionally understand something. Through private and group work, you will first verify that such emotional understanding is still lacking. You know so well that the first step towards understanding is always acknowledgment and concise verbalization of what one does not understand. This is half the battle. Let the respective persons pronounce what may be intellectually understood, but not yet emotionally understood, where it is not yet a living experience. Then the others may help for clarification, perhaps by way of examples. Personal exposure is not necessary if not desired by the person. It can be kept general. It is not to be confused with the group work. The important thing is to help you towards an emotional assimilation through a helpful hint and directive toward gaining such emotional assimilation. Others who have the experience, perhaps through having worked out a particular point under discussion, may show the way how to arrive at this assimilation.

However, if here or there something is not intellectually understood, then, of course, these study groups are the place to air it out. If your pride prevents you from doing so, it is not only to your own detriment, but also to the detriment of the entire venture. For, in order to have the right spirit, humility and honesty will make it a living, dynamic experience. The opposite will make it dull and dragging.

The speed in which these study groups can grow into a meaningful venture depends (1) on the pride of the timid ones who do not wish to expose their "ignorance" and (2) on the pride of the boisterous ones who give forth with their "knowledge," who show off with it so as to impress others. Both have burning questions, some of them quite conscious, others vague about their confusion, and out of laziness and pride do not formulate these questions. It is this type of inner nonparticipation, a passive pretense, that hinders the quality. If every participant prepares by voicing what he does not understand intellectually and/or emotionally, I can promise that these discussion groups will turn out profitable for all concerned.

Let this type of venture also serve you as an opportunity to probe yourself. What is the motive for giving forth? What is the motive for not doing so? To the degree that you voice your confusions, to that degree these discussions will prove of immeasurable value. The help will then be given to the one who pronounces his confusion, but equally to others -- last but not least by the

example that is set. Then it will truly become a school, but in which each one is pupil and teacher at the same time. If you keep this in mind and try to live it, all outer details will easily fall into place. They are unimportant. Trial and error, and improvements you will make along the way will be easy and without friction. If this basic spirit prevails with the majority of my friends, this spirit will then draw the others along because it is the strength of the spirit that matters. And even those who are too timid and blind and lazy will be swept along by the truthfulness, by the self-honesty, by getting rid of the pride of some of you. This will make the venture a blossoming one. This is what I have to suggest.

QUESTION: I have a personal question. It refers to this lecture. Many years ago, following a dream interpretation you then gave me, I found out that I am hiding my guilt behind something else, that the guilt feeling in regard to my mother was really something else. Now I found out that I don't love myself, and therefore, if I don't love myself, how can I love others? I felt all of a sudden that this might be the real guilt. When you came to the second part of this lecture, about the unwillingness of going through the day's little chores, I realized that this also holds true for me, and the idea came to me that perhaps I am hiding my real guilt because I am egocentric.

ANSWER: You are quite right, but you will have to find particularly how this holds true, how this egocentricity manifests. It has to become more than mere general knowledge. Your momentary awakening is the first step in the right direction in this particular respect. It is truly a new awareness of self, a real awakening. You may now recall that I often said that overperfectionism is a substitute for withdrawing from loving in one form or another. The more the soul, due to its development, due to its characteristics, is ready for loving, or to put it differently, the greater the potential for spiritual development and the more this is obstructed, the greater is the protest. And therefore the protest itself, unpleasant as it may feel, is the medicine. I said this so often, but it is not yet fully understood. Nor do human psychologists sufficiently understand that the neurosis itself is, in a sense, the first step to the cure of the soul. The sickness is not caused by outer events, but by violation of the soul, preventing it from developing its potential. This is always a personal matter, in the last analysis a spiritual, moral one -- a question of one's integrity in regard to one's natural cosmic forces, as opposed to prohibiting them. Without painful manifestation, the person would be unaware that something is amiss. What is considered an illness is, at the same time, a medicine. It is both. In that lies, for instance, the benign quality of the spiritual and universal laws.

On one hand, you feel a great love force. It is a part of your nature. But it is counteracted by a prohibition. And it is this prohibition that causes the problems. You have to find it specifically. You are almost there. You actually find yourself on the threshold of the full realization of this most fundamental core. This feeling of not daring to love may apply only to certain areas of your life, not to all relationships. Then, when you verify this point, you will ascertain the real guilt that produces the unjustified guilts as well as the perfectionism.

My dearest, dearest friends, the love force, the life force, is abundantly flowing towards each one of you, also to my absent friends. I think you can all feel it. You feel the light and the strength. Rejoice on this path. There is nothing more meaningful. There is nothing that makes more sense no matter how painful life may sometimes be, no matter how many times you may feel a relapse or a stagnation. If you do not give up, but persevere, the light will become steadier and stronger. If you are more outspoken and more direct, this entire group will grow more and more. Then it will become a more frequent occurrence that those who find themselves in a hopeless depression will

not hide. Instead, they will go to those who find themselves strong at the moment, who have successfully passed through such stages and have come out of it through this work. They will communicate with them and will thus be helped instead of reacting in a different way. This is then true brotherhood, this is then true relating. In this, you all have much to learn. You are at the beginning of a very concise stage of your development. You all have learned a great deal and have thus come nearer to the point where this group as a whole can truly become a functional love group.

And now, be blessed, all of you. Be in peace and in God!

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The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
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